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"This is real, we did it": Bronx tena become their own landlord

By **Shosh Bedrosian**
Updated on: March 13, 2024 / 6:36 PM EDT / CBS New York

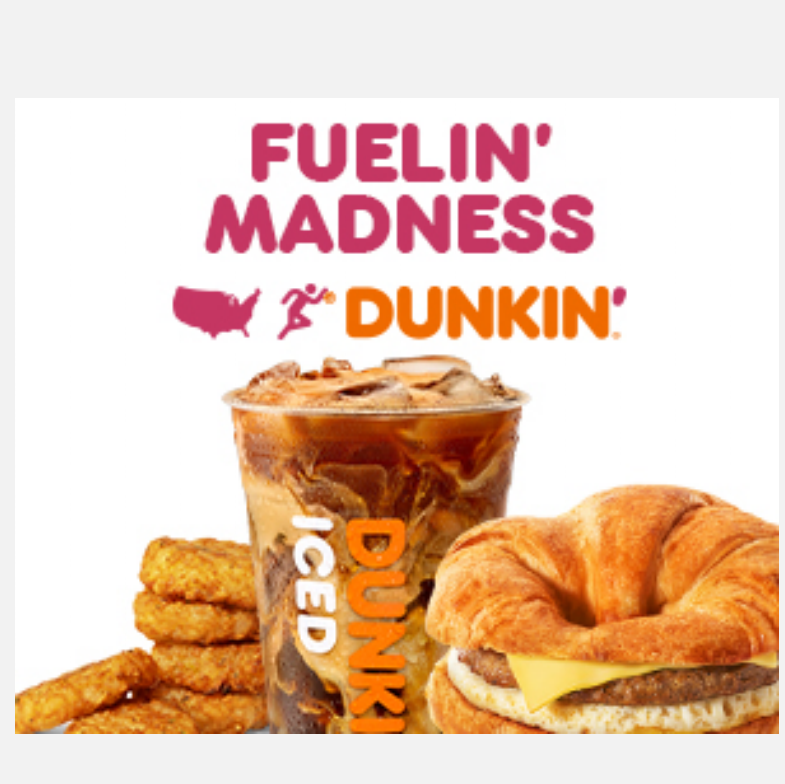
NEW YORK -- CBS New York first brought you a story last week about tenants in the Bronx filing a lawsuit against their landlord for not making basic repairs and for living in unsafe conditions.

Well those tenants want to transition their building to be a tenant-owned building.

It's been six months of walking six flights of stairs for resident Nora Brown.

"I can't take it," she says.

The elevator in her building has been broken since August. But residents say that's just another item on the laundry list their landlord has refused to fix for decades.



"Some of the damages in this building include garbages, roaches, rats, and constant ineffective elevators," said Janelle Young, a resident.

Tenants at 2201 Davidson Ave., filed a lawsuit against their landlord for failing to make basic repairs. And in order to get their building into better shape, they want one thing.

"That this building should be transferred to the tenants. They cannot live a day longer in these conditions," said Edward Garcia, of Northwest Bronx Community and Clergy Coalition

How attainable is that goal? CBS New York tracked down one building in Port Morris that successfully bought their building. The tenants there say after a long legal battle, they're just a few months away from owning their own building.

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Since 2017, tenant Courtland Hankins has fought to stay in this building at an affordable price.

"The new owner came in and made it pretty clear our rents were going to go up and be increased pretty quickly and pretty significantly. 50% and almost double," said Hankins.

On the outskirts of gentrified Mott Haven stands 700 East 134th St., a real estate hot bed. Hankins and other tenants also took their fight to court, but ultimately forced their landlord's hand to selling the building to them.

"Sometimes it feels surreal because like I have to pinch myself this is real we did it," said resident Claudia Waterton.

With the help from UHAB, Urban Homesteading Assistance Board, and the City's Housing Preservation & Development, tenants purchased the building for under $4 million in 2022.

"If I need something fixed it gets fixed. I don't have to like keep going back and forth with the landlord," said Waterton.

From the new windows, heating and cooling systems and stoves, they've already started making upgrades.

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"Our ceilings are extremely high so it would not be enough to cool the whole unit. So now with these new heat pumps they put in, my unit gets cool like that," said Waterton.

Hankins says his best advice for tenants at 2201 Davidson Ave., in this process is, "Unity, sticking together, throughout the process has been the number one reason why we've gotten this far. It's a beautiful thing. The power is in our hands and just need to make sure we cooperate with one another,"

Tenants are now pushing for the state to pass a bill called TOPA, which would give tenants the right to make the first offer on their building if the landlord wants to sell it.

You can email Shosh with Bronx story ideas by CLICKING HERE.

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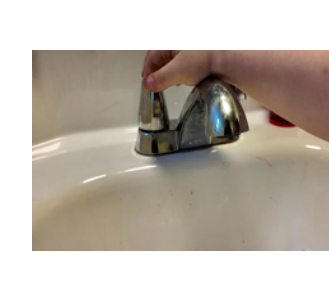
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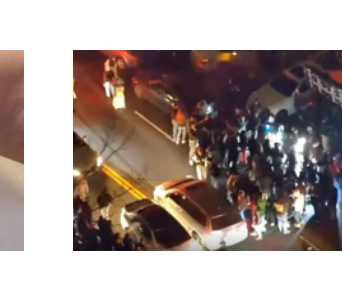
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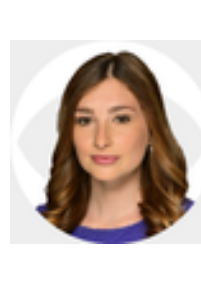
Shosh Bedrosian joined CBS News New York as a reporter in March 2023, focusing her reporting on the Bronx.

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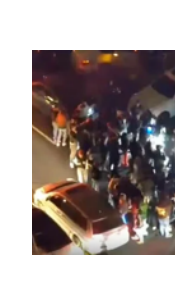
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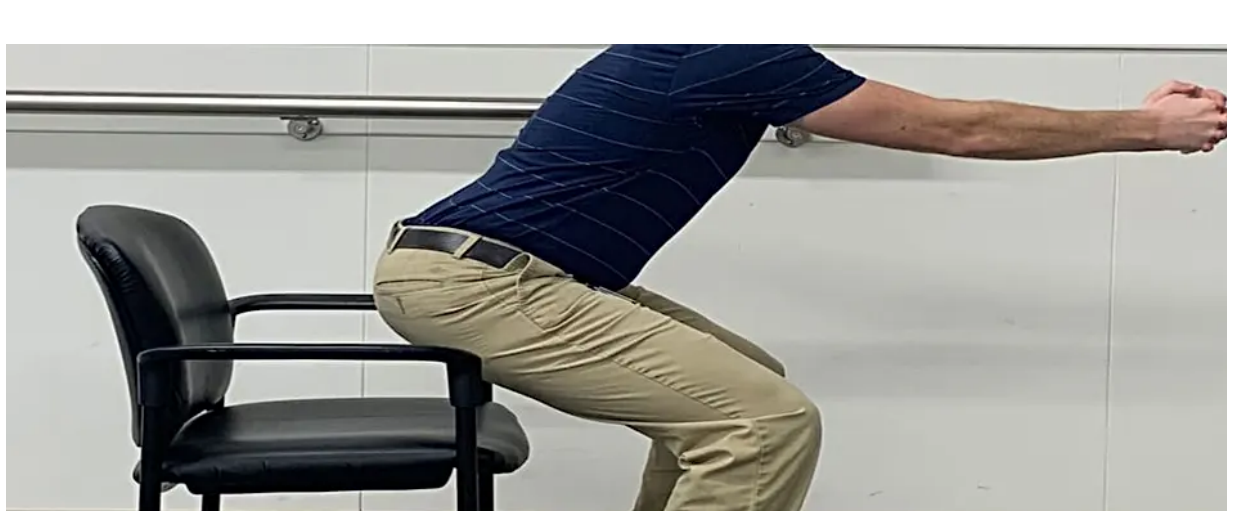
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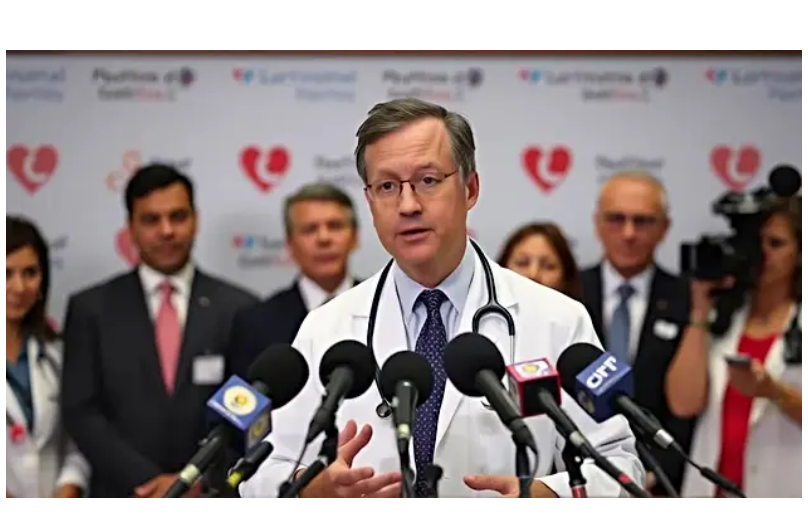
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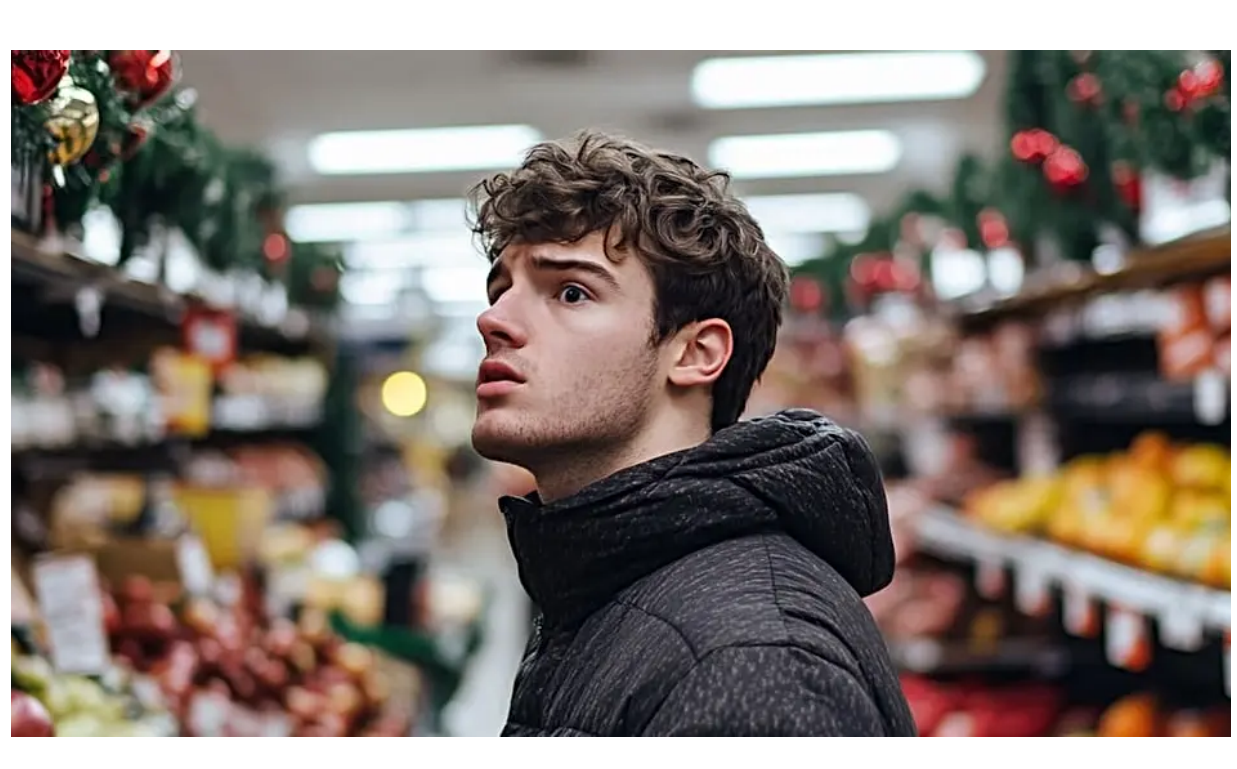
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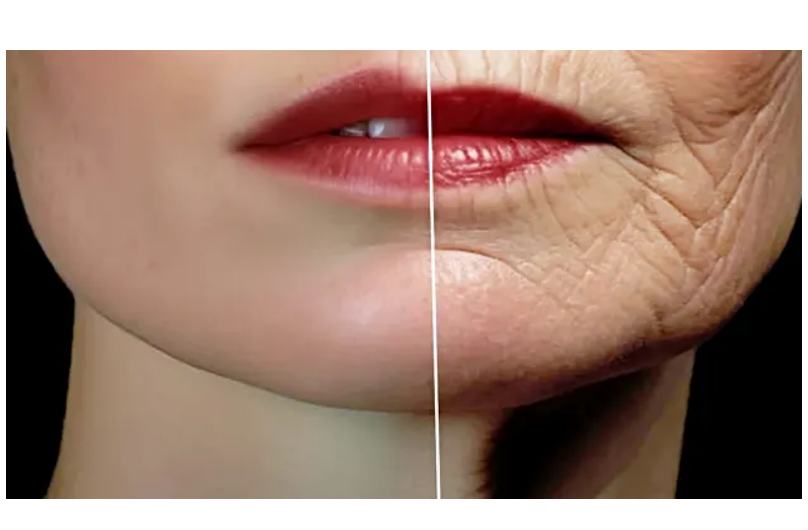
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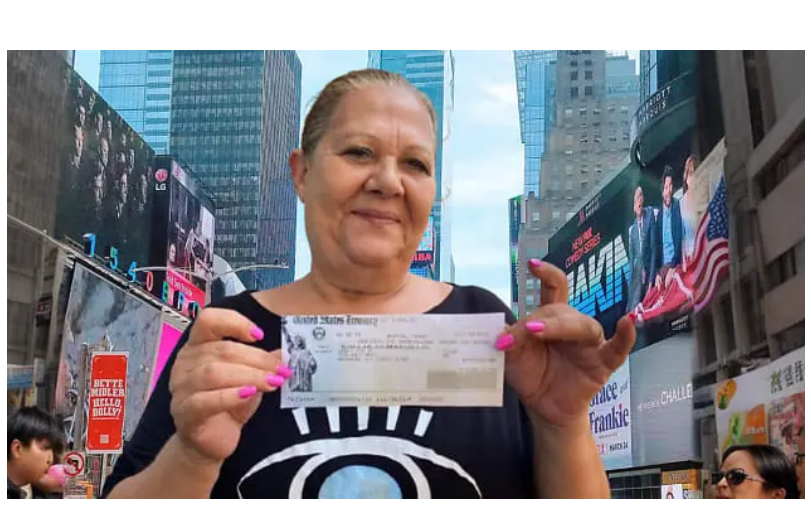
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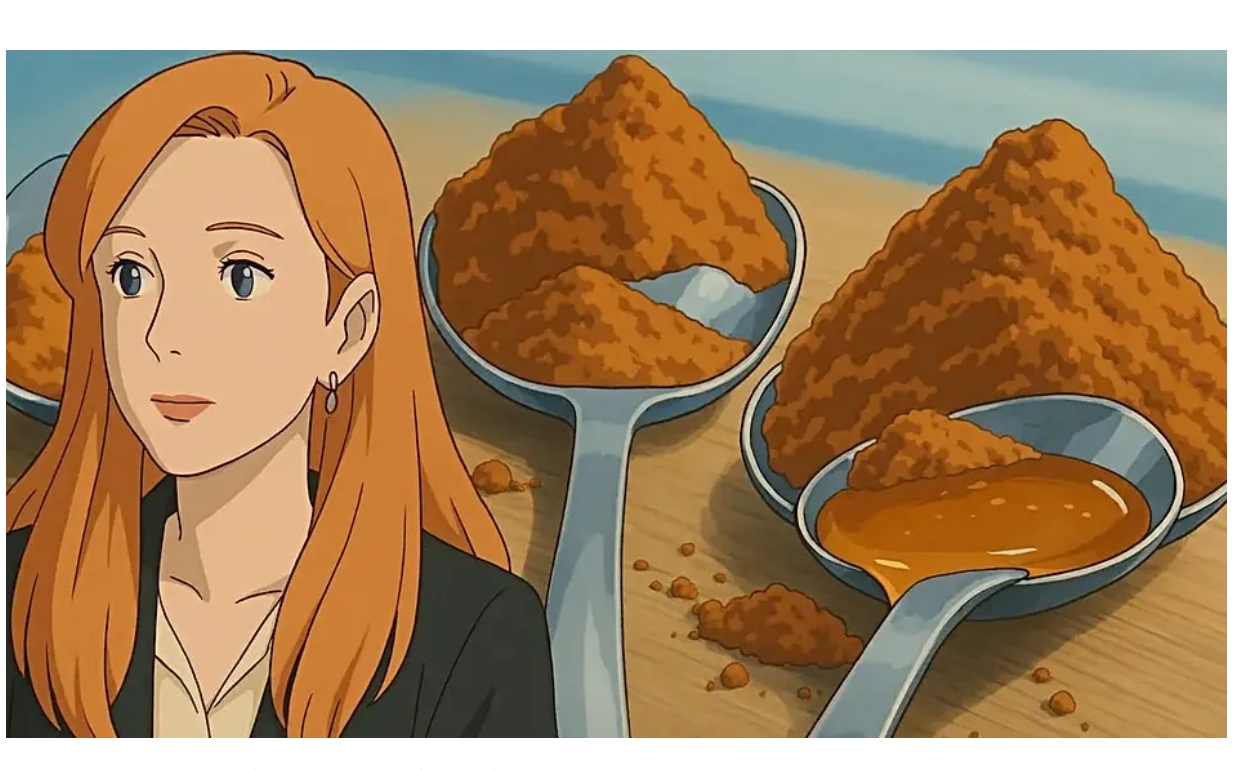
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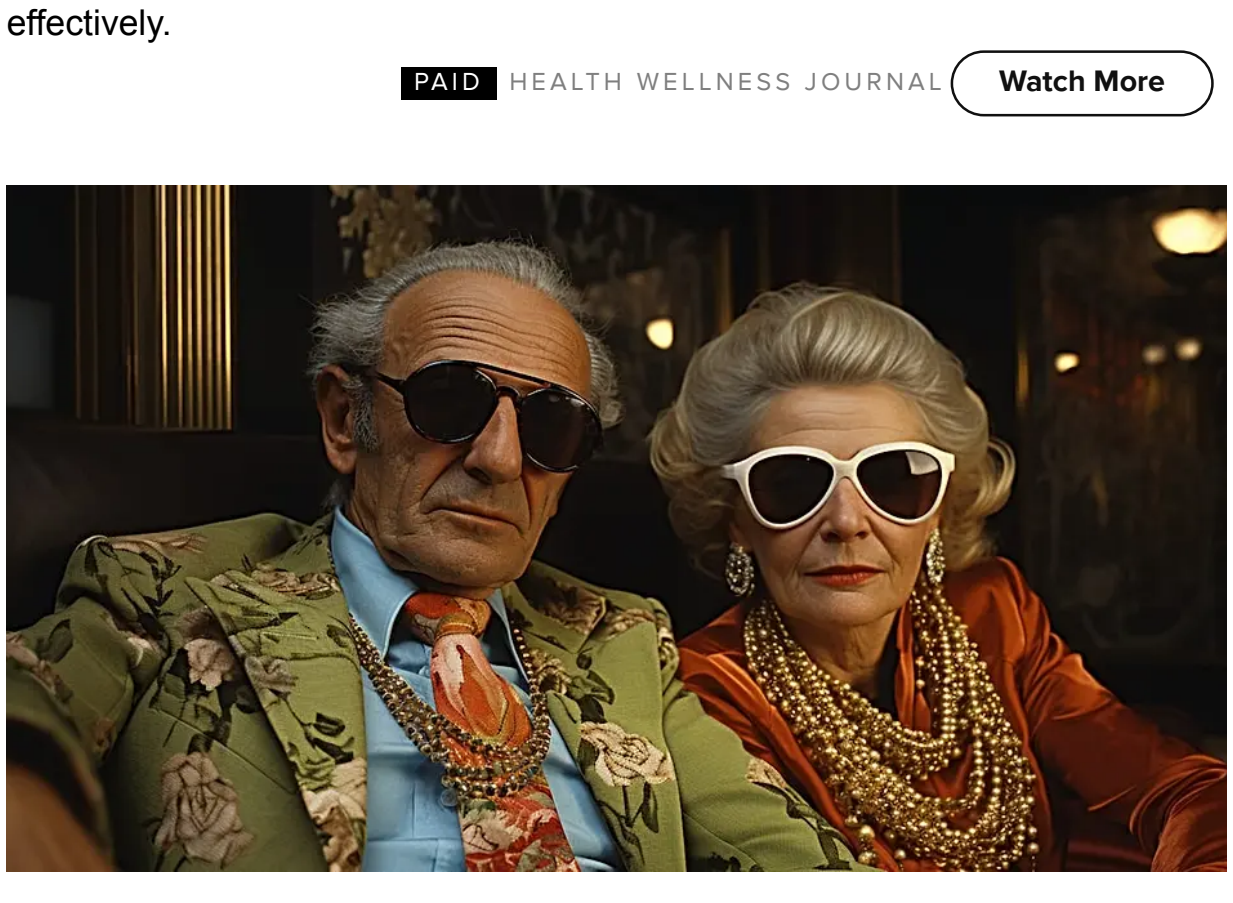
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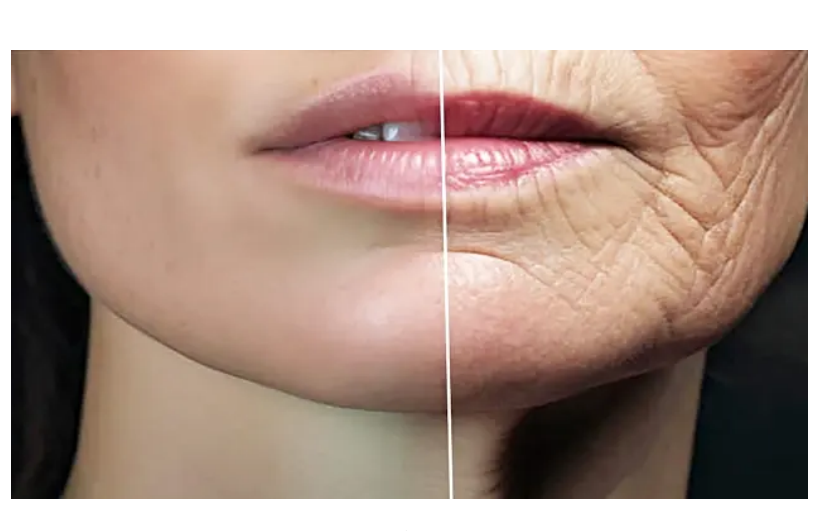
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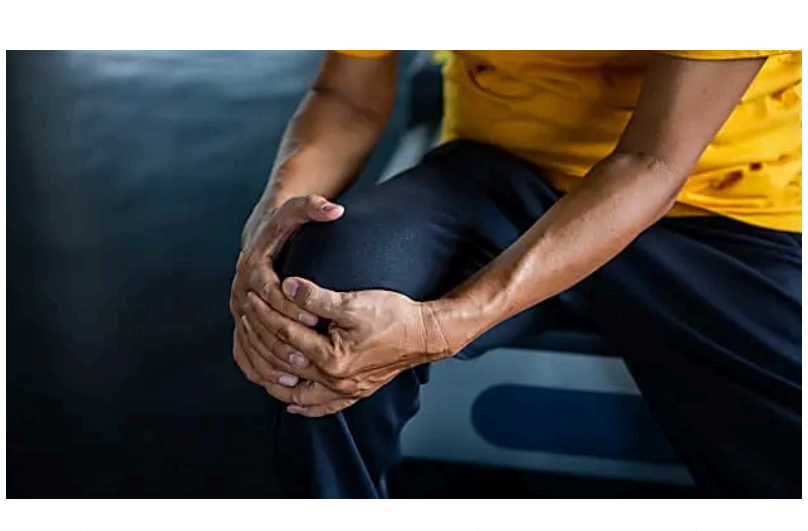
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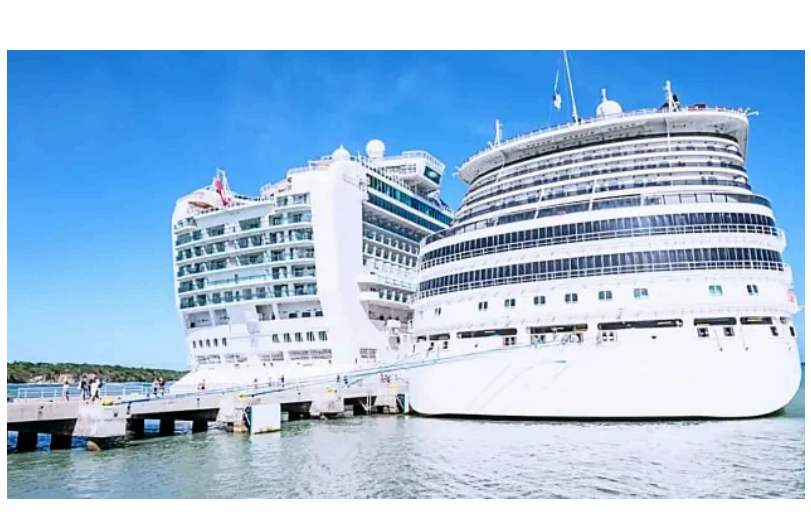
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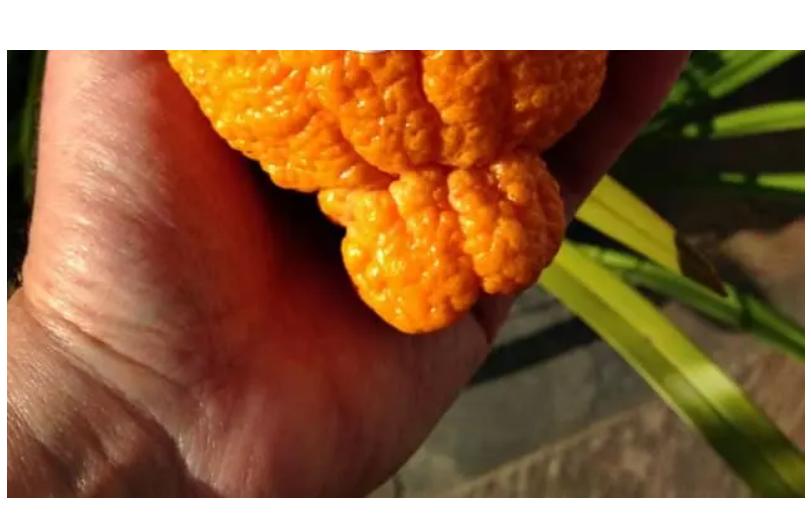
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